

CHESS MASTERY LIBRARY | 1.d4 + c4 REPERTOIRE

Course Guide and Repertoire Map

A complete learning system for 1.d4 followed by c4

THE PROMISE

Know what you are building, which move belongs to each branch, and how to make the repertoire survive real games.

COURSE VOLUME 01 OF 10

SEE THE POSITION | RECALL THE PLAN | CALCULATE THE MOVE

What this volume should change

- Use one coherent move-order map against every serious first move by Black.
- Understand when c4 is the correct second move and when a forcing reply comes first.
- Learn openings as positions, plans, and retrieval cues rather than as unconnected notation.
- Maintain the repertoire from your own games without constantly replacing it.

STUDY METHOD

Learn each chapter in three layers: first the trigger and plan, then the short main line, then Black's branches. Hide the page and reconstruct the line on a board. Do not memorize notation without the position's purpose.

Inside this volume

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02	The exceptions to automatic 2.c4
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Original instructional synthesis. Move sequences were legality-checked with python-chess and critical choices were reviewed with Stockfish 18. Opening-frequency context was checked against the Lichess opening explorer in September 2026. Engines verify tactics; the explanations and training design are the course's teaching layer. Diagrams use Colin M. L. Burnett's Cburnett piece artwork as distributed by Lichess under GPLv2+.

CHAPTER 01

The repertoire's identity

POSITION TRIGGER

Normal development after 1.d4: Black has not created an immediate tactical demand.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bf4



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The course claims central space with d4, challenges Black's d5 point with c4, and normally develops Nc3 before Nf3 so the Nimzo-Indian can be met directly. The repertoire is classical and positional, but not passive: White uses structural pressure, timely central breaks, and superior piece routes. The anchor line is not a promise of an automatic advantage. It is a reliable gateway to positions whose plans repeat across many defenses.

White's plan

- Build the center, develop efficiently, and castle before starting a wing operation.
- Identify the pawn structure before recalling moves; the structure tells you which plan the line was chosen to reach.
- Prefer a useful developing move when exact memory ends, unless a tactical feature demands calculation.

What Black is trying to do

- Black may attack d4 directly, concede the center and counterattack it, or close the center and play on a wing.
- Different move orders can transpose to the same structure; names matter less than the position reached.
- Equalization is not the end of the game. The repertoire aims for sound positions you understand deeply.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
1...d5	Play 2.c4 and use the Queen's Gambit volumes.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
1...Nf6	Play 2.c4; after ...e6 use 3.Nc3, and after ...g6 use 3.Nc3.
1...f5	Play 2.c4 and head for the fianchetto system with g3 and Bg2.
1...e6	Play 2.c4. Black will usually reveal a QGD, Nimzo, Dutch, or English Defense.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Think in positions, not labels. If 1...e6 2.c4 f5 appears, use the Dutch chapter; if 1...Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 d5 appears, use the QGD chapter.

MEMORY HOOK

d4 builds; c4 questions; development decides how the answer is handled.

CHAPTER 02

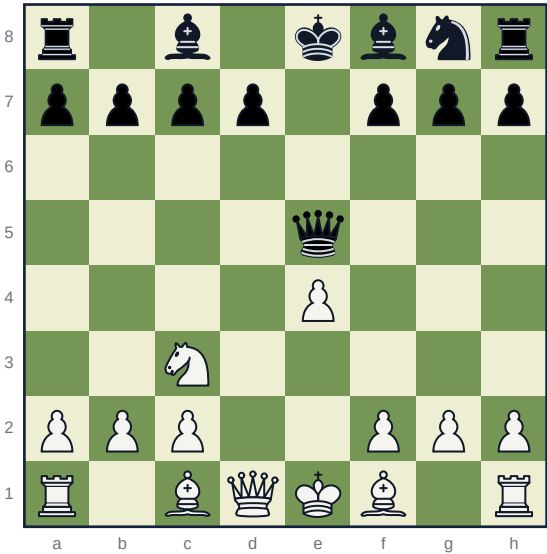
The exceptions to automatic 2.c4

POSITION TRIGGER

Black's first move attacks d4 immediately or creates a forcing tactical question.

Your anchor line

1. d4 e5 2. dxe5 Nc6 3. Nf3 Qe7 4. Nc3 Nxe5 5. Nxe5 Qxe5 6. e4



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

A repertoire is a decision system, not a ritual. Against the Englund Gambit, accepting the pawn and developing accurately is more principled than playing 2.c4 while Black's pawn attacks d4. Against 1...c5, advancing 2.d5 secures space and avoids allowing ...cxd4 on favorable terms. These exceptions strengthen the 1.d4 identity because they answer Black's concrete challenge first.

White's plan

- Ask what changed before reaching automatically for the c-pawn.
- Against 1...e5, accept with 2.dxe5 and meet checks with development, not pawn grabbing.
- Against 1...c5, use 2.d5 and then build with Nc3 and e4 when Black permits it.

What Black is trying to do

- Gambit lines try to replace strategic play with one tactical trap.
- Early queen moves can win a pawn only if White cooperates by chasing material.
- Unusual first moves often transpose after White completes d4, c4, Nc3, and Nf3 in a sensible order.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
1...e5	2.dxe5. Develop Nf3 and Nc3; refuse to protect the extra pawn at the cost of coordination.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
1...c5	2.d5. Build a Benoni-style center with Nc3 and e4 if possible.
1...Nc6	2.Nf3. Keep e4 controlled; play c4 after Black reveals ...d5 or ...e5.
1...b5	2.e4 Bb7 3.Bd3. Occupy the center before deciding whether c4 is useful.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

The phrase '1.d4 and 2.c4' describes the repertoire's main skeleton. Forcing threats and immediate attacks on d4 take precedence.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer the threat, then return to the structure.

CHAPTER 03

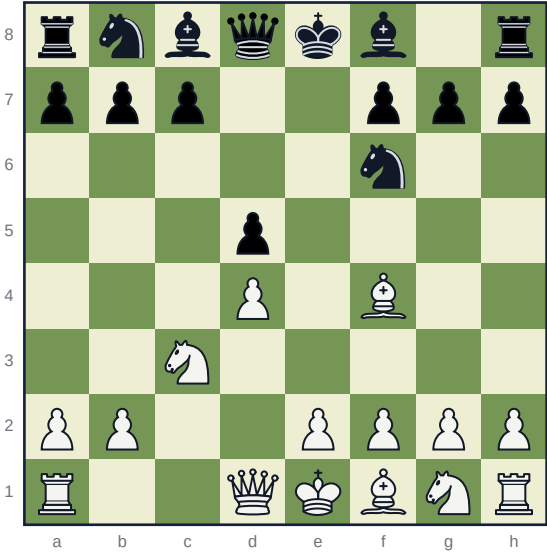
Map after 1...d5

POSITION TRIGGER

Black mirrors the center with 1...d5 and White challenges it with 2.c4.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bf4



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The 1...d5 family divides by what Black does with the c-pawn and the d5 pawn. If Black protects d5 with ...e6, choose the QGD Exchange structure. If Black protects with ...c6, use the Slow Slav. If Black captures on c4, use the QGA development scheme. Early ...c5, ...Nc6, or ...e5 lead to the Tarrasch, Chigorin, or Albin chapters. This map prevents name overload: classify the center first.

White's plan

- Against ...e6, exchange on d5 and develop Bf4 before e3 when the move order permits.
- Against ...c6, use Nf3 and e3, then attack the active light bishop with Nh4 when appropriate.
- Against ...dxc4, regain the pawn with Bxc4 after e3; do not waste tempi trying to hold it immediately.

What Black is trying to do

- Black can delay ...e6 or ...c6, making you identify the defense one move later.
- Black may play ...a6, ...Bf5, or ...Nc6 before the usual setup; each changes one tactical detail, not the entire repertoire.
- The most dangerous sidelines are those that strike d4 before White is ready.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
2...e6	3.Nc3 and the QGD Exchange plan.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
2...c6	3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 and the Slow Slav.
2...dxc4	3.Nf3, 4.e3, and Bxc4.
2...Nc6 / 2...e5 / 2...c5	Use the Chigorin / Albin / Tarrasch chapters.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not force the Exchange Variation against the Slav: after ...c6, cxd5 releases Black's c-pawn and often solves Black's development problem.

MEMORY HOOK

e6 means exchange; c6 means build; dxc4 means develop and recover.

CHAPTER 04

Map after 1...Nf6

POSITION TRIGGER

Black develops without committing the central pawns: 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. e3



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

White chooses 3.Nc3 against ...e6, deliberately allowing the Nimzo-Indian and answering it with the Rubinstein Variation. Against ...g6, play 3.Nc3; ...d5 is the Gruenfeld and ...Bg7 followed by ...d6 is the King's Indian. Against ...c5, 3.d5 enters Benoni or Benko structures. The third move is a classification tool: Nc3 when the center remains fluid, d5 when ...c5 directly challenges d4.

White's plan

- Meet ...e6 with Nc3 and be ready for either ...Bb4 or ...d5.
- Meet ...g6 with Nc3, then distinguish ...d5 from ...Bg7 and ...d6.
- Meet ...c5 with d5; preserve the space advantage and accept structural concessions only for clear activity.

What Black is trying to do

- Black can transpose between Indian defenses through ...e6, ...g6, ...c5, and ...d5.
- The Nimzo may surrender the bishop pair to damage c-pawns; the course teaches when that damage is an asset or liability.
- The King's Indian and Gruenfeld attack the center differently, so the same-looking setup requires different timing.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
2...e6 3.Nc3 Bb4	4.e3: Rubinstein Nimzo-Indian.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
2...e6 3.Nc3 d5	4.cxd5: QGD Exchange by transposition.
2...g6 3.Nc3 d5	4.Nf3 and 5.Bf4: controlled Gruenfeld system.
2...g6 3.Nc3 Bg7	4.e4 d6 5.Nf3: Classical King's Indian.
2...c5	3.d5 and use the Benoni/Benko volume.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not decide by opening name before Black commits the d-pawn. The pawn on d5 creates a Gruenfeld; the pawn on d6 creates a King's Indian shell.

MEMORY HOOK

e6: Nc3. g6: Nc3. c5: d5.

CHAPTER 05

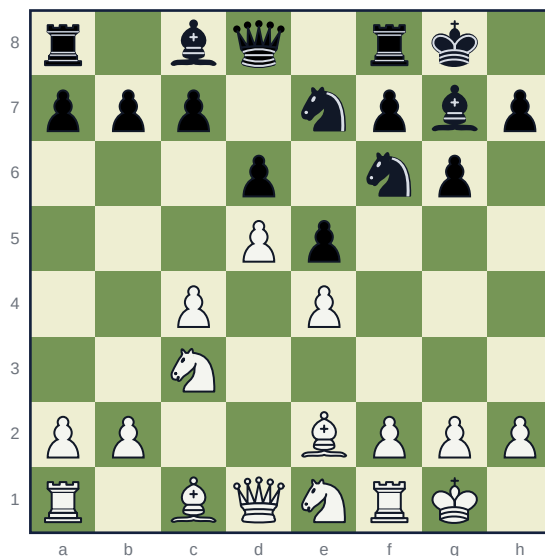
Three layers of memory

POSITION TRIGGER

You can explain a chapter but cannot yet reproduce all its branches.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7 9. Ne1



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

Store every opening in layers. Layer one is the trigger and plan: what position is this and what does White want? Layer two is the anchor line: a short, legal sequence reaching the tabiya. Layer three is the branch map: Black's important alternatives and the adjustment each requires. Learn in that order. If notation fades during a game, layer one can still produce a good move; isolated memorization cannot.

White's plan

- Recall the trigger from a diagram before looking at moves.
- Reconstruct the anchor line on a physical or digital board from both sides.
- Add branches only after the anchor and plan are stable.
- Write one sentence explaining why the final White move belongs in the position.

What Black is trying to do

- A forcing line may require exact tactical memory earlier than a quiet system.
- Similar structures can contain one critical difference, such as whether Black has castled or developed the light bishop.
- Memory feels fluent while reading; retrieval must be tested with the page closed.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
Layer 1	Trigger + strategic target. Must be recalled first.
Layer 2	Anchor line to the main tabiya. Rebuild it without prompts.
Layer 3	Branches, tactical exceptions, and exact move-order details.
Layer 4	Your own games and model games. Add only after the course is usable.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not test recognition by rereading. Start from an empty board, play both colors, and stop at each Black choice to name your reply before moving.

MEMORY HOOK

Plan first, spine second, branches third.

CHAPTER 06

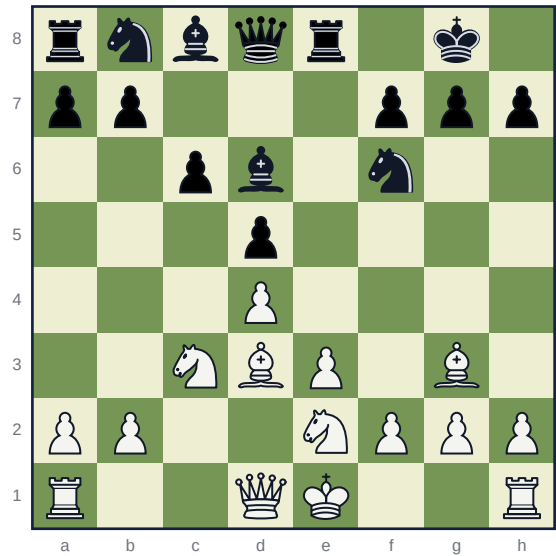
The model-game method

POSITION TRIGGER

You know the opening position but your play becomes aimless after move ten.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bf4 c6 6. e3 Bd6 7. Bg3 O-O 8. Bd3 Re8 9. Nge2



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

An opening line tells you where the middlegame begins; a model game tells you how it breathes. Study one model for each major structure by pausing at every White move after the opening. Predict the plan, not just the move. Then summarize the game in three moments: the first strategic commitment, the pawn break that changed the position, and the conversion or defensive technique. This is how the PDFs become playable knowledge.

White's plan

- Choose model games that reach your exact structure, even if the opening move order differs.
- Before each White move, name the worst-placed piece and the relevant pawn break.
- After the game, replay only the three turning points from memory.

What Black is trying to do

- A spectacular tactical win can hide the ordinary maneuvers you most need to learn.
- Grandmaster games sometimes rely on precise calculation; copy the plan, not every move.
- A model game is evidence for a plan, not proof that the plan always works.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
Carlsbad	Find a minority-attack game and a central-break game.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
Nimzo	Find one game using the bishop pair and one exploiting doubled c-pawns.
King's Indian	Find one queenside breakthrough and one successful Black kingside attack.
Benko	Find one game where White neutralizes pressure before using the extra pawn.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not add random annotated games to the study queue. Every chosen game must answer a question created by one chapter in this course.

MEMORY HOOK

Opening line gives the position; model game gives the future.

CHAPTER 07

The first-memory-failure review

POSITION TRIGGER

A serious game has ended and you want to update the repertoire.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. e3 O-O 5. Bd3 d5 6. Nf3 c5 7. O-O



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

Review the game without an engine first. Mark the first position where you no longer knew the plan or could not reconstruct your intended move. That point, not the later blunder, is the opening study target. Write your candidate and reason, check the course, then use an engine only to test tactics and alternatives. Add one concise note to the PDF's personal-notes section or a separate PGN. The stable repertoire grows from evidence rather than anxiety.

White's plan

- Locate the first memory failure, not merely the first engine inaccuracy.
- Classify the failure: missing line, missing plan, tactical oversight, or move-order confusion.
- Create one recall prompt that would have exposed the gap before the next game.

What Black is trying to do

- Engine evaluations can tempt you to replace a sound repertoire because another move scores a few centipawns better.
- A bad result does not prove an opening is bad; look for a repeatable decision problem.
- Changing lines too often destroys pattern accumulation.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
Forgot the line	Rebuild the branch and test it after one day, three days, and one week.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
Forgot the plan	Study a model game from the resulting structure.
Missed a tactic	Create a diagram puzzle at the moment before the tactic.
Disliked the position	Play training games from the tabiya before replacing the line.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Keep the course stable for at least twenty serious games unless a line is tactically unsound. Familiarity compounds only when the structure recurs.

MEMORY HOOK

Find the first fog, classify it, repair one thing.

CHAPTER 08

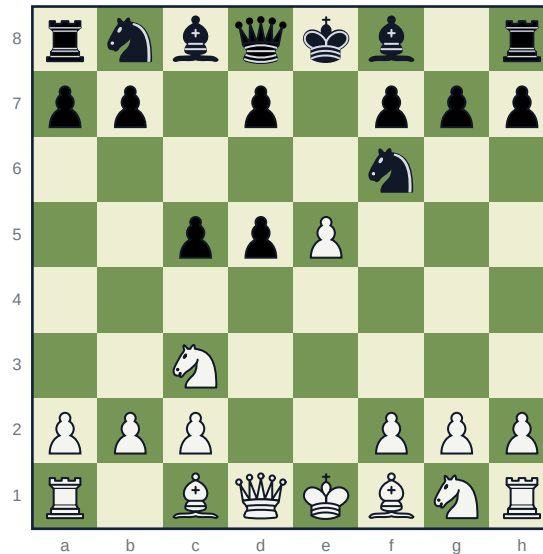
A sustainable weekly schedule

POSITION TRIGGER

You want a complete course without letting opening study consume all chess time.

Your anchor line

1. d4 c5 2. d5 Nf6 3. Nc3 e6 4. e4 exd5 5. e5



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

Completeness does not mean learning every volume immediately. Build a minimum playable tree first: the guide, QGD, Slav, Nimzo, King's Indian, and one rare-defense card. Then deepen the branch you actually encounter. A useful weekly schedule gives openings two short retrieval sessions, one model game, and one training game. Calculation, tactics, endgames, and game review still deserve most of the week.

White's plan

- Day 1: reconstruct two anchor lines and solve one course test.
- Day 3: study one model game from the current structure.
- Day 5: play or analyze a training game beginning from a tabiya.
- Weekend: review your first memory failure and schedule one repair.

What Black is trying to do

- Opening study expands to fill time because recognition feels productive.
- Rare lines are easy to over-study relative to how often they occur.
- A complete repertoire still cannot predict every legal move; principles bridge the gaps.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
First month	Guide + one volume at a time; learn only anchor lines and plans.
Second month	Add branch maps and one model game per major structure.
After twenty games	Use your encounter list to decide which volume deserves depth.
Every quarter	Audit lines for repeated practical problems, not novelty for its own sake.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

If you cannot recall last week's material, reduce new input. More pages are not the cure for weak retrieval.

MEMORY HOOK

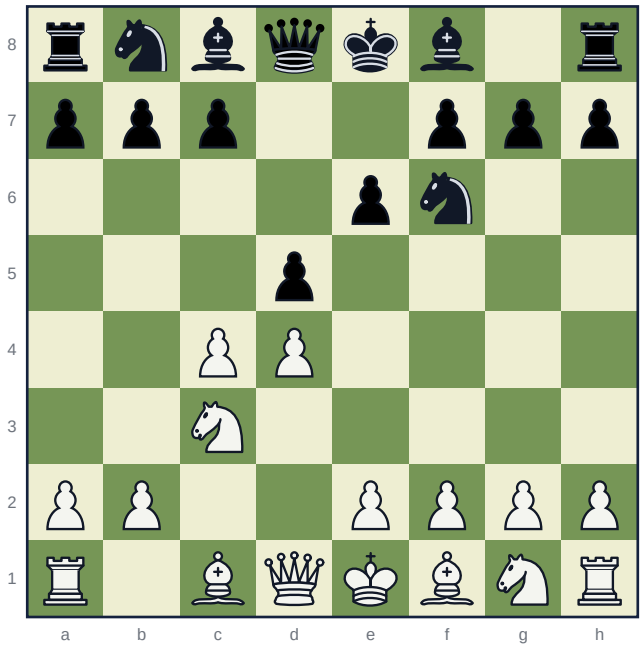
Small tree first; deepen where your games create evidence.

Repertoire Test

For every position, name the opening branch, state your strategic objective, and choose a move. The answer is not only a move: it is a move attached to a reason.

TEST 01 | Classify 1...d5

Which repertoire family has Black chosen, and what is White's structural commitment?



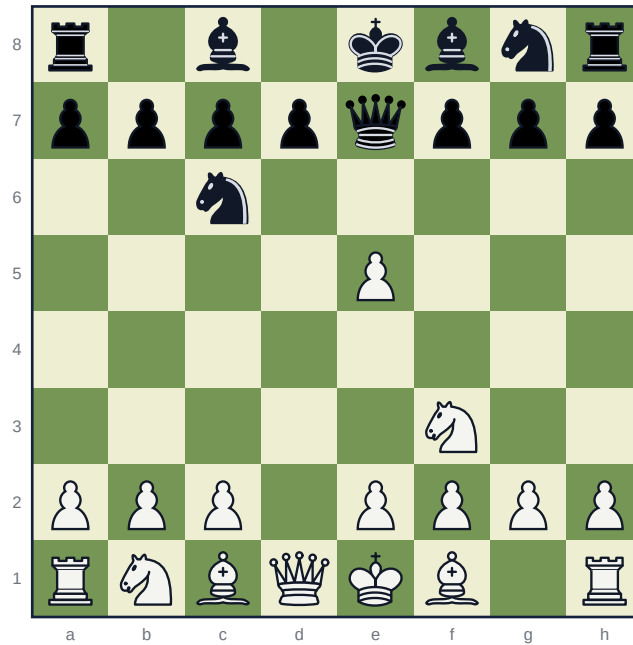
Position reached by: 1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 02 | Do not automate c4

Why is a normal developing response more important than trying to preserve the extra pawn?



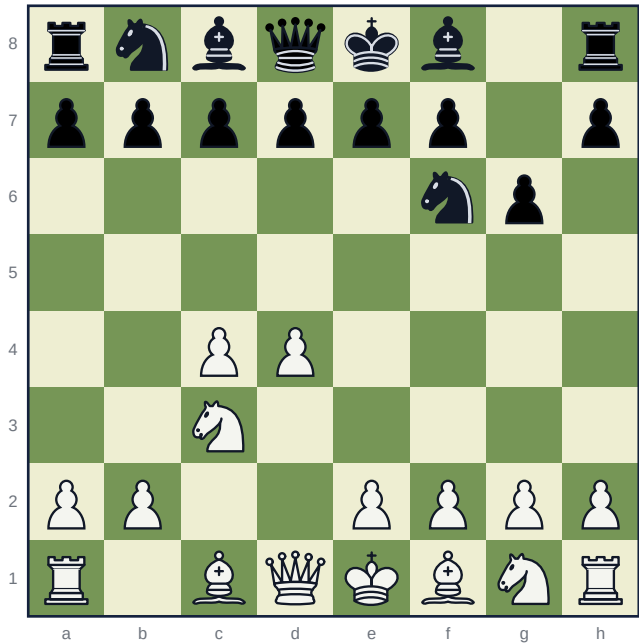
Position reached by: 1. d4 e5 2. dxe5 Nc6 3. Nf3 Qe7

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 03 | Indian-defense fork

What single Black move separates the Gruenfeld from the King's Indian plan?



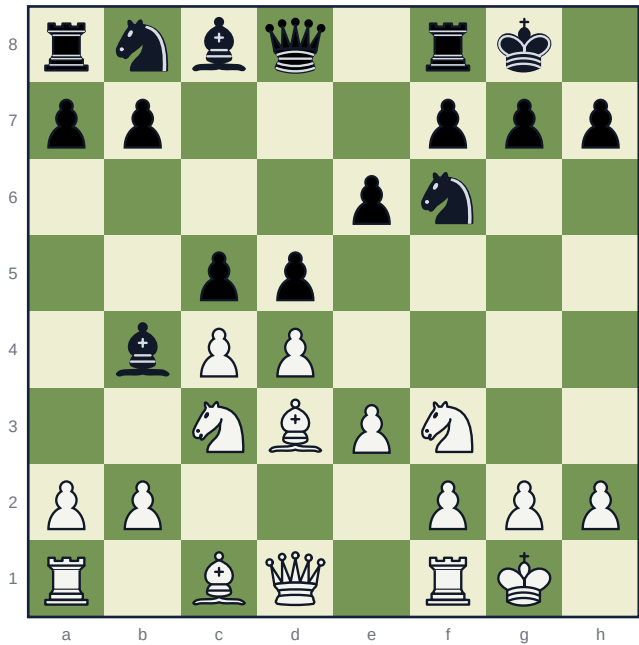
Position reached by: 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 04 | Review correctly

Your game continued with an improvised move and later a tactical loss. What should be reviewed first?



Position reached by: 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. e3 O-O 5. Bd3 d5 6. Nf3 c5 7. O-O

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

Repertoire Test - Answers

TEST 01 | Classify 1...d5

This is the QGD. Play 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Bf4. White commits to the Exchange structure and plans e3, Bd3, Nge2, and either a minority attack or a central break.

TEST 02 | Do not automate c4

Black's compensation depends on tempi against White's queen and king. Develop with 4.Nc3. If ...Nxe5, exchanges favor the sounder side; after 5.Nxe5 Qxe5 6.e4 White owns the center and can complete development.

TEST 03 | Indian-defense fork

The commitment is ...d5. After 3...d5 use 4.Nf3 and 5.Bf4. After 3...Bg7 4.e4 d6, use the Classical King's Indian setup with Nf3 and Be2.

TEST 04 | Review correctly

First review why you left the known tabiya and whether you understood the center. Reconstruct the intended Nimzo plan before checking the later tactic. Then create a separate tactical prompt if the tactic represents a recurring calculation weakness.

One-Page Recall Card

Cover the right column. Read the trigger and say the memory hook. Then cover the left column and reconstruct which position produces that hook.

Normal development after 1.d4: Black has not created an immediate tactical demand.	d4 builds; c4 questions; development decides how the answer is handled.
Black's first move attacks d4 immediately or creates a forcing tactical question.	Answer the threat, then return to the structure.
Black mirrors the center with 1...d5 and White challenges it with 2.c4.	e6 means exchange; c6 means build; dxc4 means develop and recover.
Black develops without committing the central pawns: 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4.	e6: Nc3. g6: Nc3. c5: d5.
You can explain a chapter but cannot yet reproduce all its branches.	Plan first, spine second, branches third.
You know the opening position but your play becomes aimless after move ten.	Opening line gives the position; model game gives the future.
A serious game has ended and you want to update the repertoire.	Find the first fog, classify it, repair one thing.
You want a complete course without letting opening study consume all chess time.	Small tree first; deepen where your games create evidence.

SPACED REVIEW

Review today, tomorrow, after three days, after one week, and after one month. A chapter graduates only when you can reconstruct its anchor line and explain its plan without looking.

GAME TRANSFER

After every serious game, locate the first position where your memory ended. Study from that exact fork. This turns the repertoire into a living system while keeping the PDFs as the stable foundation.